

MEMORY LOSS

Yet another book that uses Gandhi as a selling point without much success and throws up more questions than answers



GOODBYE TO GANDHI

by BERNARD IMHASLY

Viking

Price: Rs 425

Pages: 195

■ By Dilip Bobb

This is a book that could have been titled 'The Sun Still Rises in the East' or 'Birds Can Fly'. Asking if Gandhi is still relevant in India is as tired a cliché as they come and the question itself has been deemed irrelevant for years now. If only Imhasly, who has worn multiple hats—an anthropologist, a diplomat, a journalist and an author—had stuck to the sub-title 'Travels in the New India', this book could have had some resonance and reason. Gandhi, sadly, may have been largely forgotten in terms of his values but he survives as a powerful brand, something that publishers know all too well. As a marketing ploy, it may work; as the focus of a book on India at the start of 2008, it falls between too many stools. What precisely did Gandhi stand for? The value of simple living, ethics in political life, strong moral principles, the practice of non-violence, the individual over the state, small social organisms over large systems, self-denial and the evils of caste and communalism. Many are valid issues that have been overtaken by history, the market, social

changes and the demands of modernity and natural evolution. That the author, a Swiss, is married to an Indian, reported on India for many years and lives in India is enough to justify his views on the new India and whether it is headed in the right direction. By dragging Gandhi into the equation, much of the impact is diluted.

The author travels to places and cities that are equated with Gandhi—from Porbandar, the Mahatma's birth-

ERASING HIS FOOTSTEPS: The book juxtaposes Gandhi with the new India



place, and other cities in Gujarat, to Champaran, Nagpur, Imphal, Kolkata, Hyderabad and Guwahati. Imhasly tries to retrace Gandhi's footsteps, find echoes of his message and establish whether his ideals are still followed. It's a journey that serves up more questions than answers but that was inevitable considering others with the same surname have usurped the Mahatma's idealistic throne in return for paying lip service on October 2 each year, like a family heirloom that is kept locked in a cupboard and dusted off and displayed on special occasions.

The journalist in him brings out some interesting observations and encounters with social workers, industrialists, prominent personalities like Pravin Togadia and the man of the moment, chief minister of Gujarat

Narendra Modi. Imhasly's travels are also revealing in terms of attitudes and aspirations—of common people, industrialists, politicians and historians. The problem is that there is too much recounting of well-known history on Gandhi's life and work. For today's Indian reader, it carries little meaning.

Set against the backdrop of an economically resurgent India where growing affluence and modern values are in discordance with Gandhian ideals, this book suffers from stating the obvious. Large portions of the book traverse familiar ground already flogged to death by other authors, essayists and columnists. India is a vast, complex, diverse and largely paradoxical subject and to juxtapose Gandhi's vision in that wide and often contradictory spectrum is a mammoth task, one in which the author fails to deliver. ■

NEW RELEASES



POLITICAL AND INCORRECT: THE REAL INDIA, WARTS AND ALL

by TAVLEEN SINGH

HarperCollins and The Express Group

Price: Rs 395; Pages: 313

History unfolds in the noted journalist's candid columns, which trace India's journey through the socialism of the '80s and the developments of the '90s to the present-day optimism of a forward-looking state.



GANDHIAN WAY: PEACE, NON-VIOLENCE AND EMPOWERMENT CELEBRATING HUNDRED YEARS OF 'SATYAGRAH'

Edited by ANAND SHARMA

Academic Foundation

Price: Rs 3,000; Pages: 320

The Congress's tribute to the Mahatma and the satyagraha movement seeks to capture the essence of his philosophy of truth and non-violence through essays by eminent leaders, politicians and academics.



THE MAKING OF SAMOVAR: HOW A MUMBAI CAFE BECAME A METAPHOR FOR A GENERATION

by USHA R. KHANNA

Spenta Multimedia

Price: NOT LISTED; Pages: 129

What started as a café catering to artists in Bombay became the city's cultural hub. Illustrated with pictures from the past and the art of its habitués, this book tells the story of the eatery that became a legend.